

CER-01 · CERTIFICATION HANDBOOK

Certification handbook — master

The whole candidate journey in one document, with the detail
held in the seven that follow

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT
2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

This handbook is the candidate-facing contract for PCI certification. It states, in one place, what the three credentials are, who may apply, how the routes differ, how booking and fees work, what happens on examination day under proctoring, how results are decided, how to appeal, and what it takes to keep a credential current. Where an operational figure is not yet fixed, this handbook says so rather than guessing, and every stage points to the sibling document that holds the full rule.

— About this document

Document	CER-01
Series	Certification Handbook
Version	1.0
Status	draft
Date	2026-08-04
Unresolved placeholders	2

Notice. This document is an educational publication of Project Controls Institute Global, Inc., and does not constitute accounting, tax, legal, financial or other professional advice. It must not be relied upon as such. Where a topic depends on the contract or the governing law, entitlement and treatment vary by jurisdiction; take local advice.

Standards. Standards and frameworks are referred to by name and described in this publication's own words. No standard's text, tables, diagrams or question banks are reproduced. All trademarks remain the property of their respective owners, and no endorsement by any standards body, employer or vendor is implied or should be inferred.

Status. Project Controls Institute Global, Inc. is a Delaware Non-Stock Corporation. The Institute has been developed with reference to ISO/IEC 17024 personnel-certification principles and is **not accredited** by ANAB, IAS or any other accreditation body. It intends to seek 501(c)(3) recognition, which has not been granted. No governmental approval, academic equivalence, or guaranteed employment, promotion or salary outcome is claimed or implied.

Examples. All worked examples are illustrative and fictional. Figures are chosen to demonstrate a method, not to describe any real project, organisation or market. Sample examination items, where they appear, are study material maintained separately from any live examination bank.

Completeness. Passages marked **[CONFIRM: ...]** are operational or market facts that have not yet been confirmed from a cited source. A document carrying them is a working draft and is not approved for publication.

© 2026 Project Controls Institute Global, Inc. · All rights reserved.

Contents

1. How to read this handbook.....	5
1.1 What this document is	5
1.2 The map	5
1.3 Precedence	6
1.4 How to read a bracketed placeholder.....	6
2. The credentials.....	6
2.1 The suite	6
2.2 The one thing to know before you choose	6
2.3 What a credential is not	6
3. Where PCI stands	7
4. Eligibility.....	7
4.1 The requirement.....	7
4.2 Counting it honestly	7
4.3 Verification.....	7
4.4 Reasonable adjustments.....	7
5. Routes.....	8
5.1 Standard	8
5.2 Founding.....	8
5.3 Honorary	8
6. Applying	8
6.1 What the application consists of	8
6.2 What payment buys	9
6.3 Fees.....	9
7. Preparing.....	9
7.1 What you are assessed against.....	9
7.2 Training is independent of assessment	9
7.3 Using AI while you prepare	9
8. The examination	10
8.1 Confirmed format.....	10
8.2 What is deliberately not fixed	10
8.3 On the day	10
9. Results.....	10
9.1 Immediate, with a breakdown	10
9.2 When a result is held.....	11
9.3 The certification decision.....	11
9.4 If you disagree	11
10. Keeping the credential.....	11
11. Your obligations	11
12. Where candidates come unstuck	12
13. The candidate's checklist.....	12

Related	13
Sources and standards.....	13
Status and version	14

Certification handbook — master

In one paragraph. This handbook is the candidate-facing contract for PCI certification. It states, in one place, what the three credentials are, who may apply, how the routes differ, how booking and fees work, what happens on examination day under proctoring, how results are decided, how to appeal, and what it takes to keep a credential current. Where an operational figure is not yet fixed, this handbook says so rather than guessing, and every stage points to the sibling document that holds the full rule.

Who this is for. Anyone considering a PCI credential — cost engineers, planners and schedulers, project controls engineers and managers, commercial managers, quantity surveyors, PMO analysts, project finance professionals, and project, programme and portfolio managers — together with the employers and sponsors who pay for them and need to know exactly what they are buying.

1. How to read this handbook

1.1 What this document is

This is the **master handbook**. It gives the operative rule at every stage of the candidate journey and is written so that a candidate who reads nothing else is not misled about anything material. It is deliberately not the whole rulebook: each stage has a sibling document in this series that carries the reasoning, the edge cases and the procedure. Where this handbook gives you a rule in two sentences, the sibling gives you the twenty that a hard case needs.

1.2 The map

Stage	Sibling document	What it adds
Which credential	CER-02 – The credential suite: PCL-AI, PFL-AI, PML-AI	What distinguishes the three, and which one is examinable today
Am I eligible	CER-03 – Eligibility, application and reasonable adjustments	Counting experience honestly; verification; adjustments
Which route	CER-04 – Routes into PCI: standard, founding, honorary	What each route grants, and what it does not
Money and dates	CER-05 – Booking, fees, rescheduling and cancellation	The window, the cut-offs, retakes, refunds
The sitting	CER-06 – Online proctoring and the secure exam client	What is monitored, what the software can and cannot do
The outcome	CER-07 – Results, scoring, appeals and complaints	Scoring, held results, the right of appeal
Staying certified	CER-08 – Recertification, CPD and the AI-currency requirement	The three-year cycle and what counts

1.3 Precedence

This handbook summarises published PCI policy. **Where this handbook and a published policy differ, the published policy prevails.** Policies are updated as the scheme matures; before you rely on a specific provision — a fee, a window, a deadline, a procedural step — check the current published policy. Nothing in this handbook creates a right to a credential.

1.4 How to read a bracketed placeholder

Where you see a bracketed **CONFIRM** marker, an operational figure is genuinely not yet fixed, and the Institute has chosen to show you the gap rather than fill it with a plausible number. Those figures are confirmed at checkout or in the published policy before they can affect you. This is the same discipline the Institute applies to its own status: see §3.

— 2. The credentials

2.1 The suite

PCI certifies a suite of three co-launching credentials, all at **Leader** level, all valid for **three years**:

Code	Full name	Category
PCL-AI	PCI AI Project Controls Leader	Project controls
PFL-AI	PCI AI Project Finance Leader	Project finance
PML-AI	PCI Project Management Leader – AI	Project management

A fourth, separate offering — the **AI in Project Controls — Specialist Certificate (AIPC)** — is a certificate, not one of the three credentials. It is open entry with no prerequisite.

2.2 The one thing to know before you choose

Only PCL-AI has a published examination blueprint. PFL-AI and PML-AI have competency sets but no published blueprint — no domain weightings and no item counts. If you need to know precisely what will be assessed before you commit, PCL-AI is the credential where that information exists today. [CER-02](#) sets out the difference in full, and [EXB-01 – Examination blueprint – PCL-AI](#) is the blueprint itself.

2.3 What a credential is not

Two distinctions that candidates get wrong, and that this handbook would rather you got right now than after paying:

1. **Certification is not membership.** PCI membership grades — Student Member (SPCI), Associate Member (APCI), Professional Member (MPCI) and Fellow (FPCI) — are a separate ladder. A credential is earned by examination; a grade is a membership standing. Buying membership does not certify you, and holding a credential is not the same as holding a grade.

2. **The honorary route is not an examined credential.** The honorary route confers the designation Honorary Fellow (PCI) by board conferral and **requires no examination**. It does not award PCL-AI, PFL-AI or PML-AI. See §5.3 and [CER-04](#).
-

— 3. Where PCI stands

PCI is a **founding-stage** certification body and says so plainly. Its certification framework is developed with reference to **ISO/IEC 17024 personnel-certification principles**. PCI is **not accredited** by ANAB, IAS or any other ISO/IEC 17024 accreditation body, and claims no governmental recognition, no university equivalence and no employment or salary outcome.

Three consequences you should read as commitments rather than caveats:

1. Operations described here in the future tense — the job-task analysis, the standard-setting study, the published recertification rules — are confirmed before they bind a candidate.
2. The Institute publishes what is not yet settled. This handbook contains bracketed placeholders for exactly that reason.
3. What the credential attests is assessed competence at the point of assessment, and thereafter under maintenance. Nothing more, and nothing less.

The Institute's published accreditation roadmap runs: standard defined — **we are here** — then student enrolment, then accreditation, then recognition.

— 4. Eligibility

4.1 The requirement

Three years of professional experience, in any field, counted on a full-time-equivalent basis. There is no degree requirement and the experience need not be in project controls.

4.2 Counting it honestly

Part-time work counts pro rata. Concurrent roles count once. Self-employment and contracting count. Career breaks do not reset the clock. [CER-03](#) works through each of these, including the cases that genuinely are ambiguous.

4.3 Verification

You declare your experience in the application, and PCI may verify what you declare **on a sample or risk basis**. A misstatement is treated as an integrity matter, not a paperwork error.

4.4 Reasonable adjustments

PCI provides reasonable adjustments so that candidates with disabilities or specific needs demonstrate their capability on equal terms. **Request an adjustment before you book, not on the day**. The standard never changes: adjustments remove barriers that have nothing to do with

the competence being assessed. The request routes, the evidence that may be asked for and the confidentiality rules are in [CER-03](#) §6.

— 5. Routes

5.1 Standard

Apply, pay the examination fee, sit the examination, and earn the credential by passing it. This is the route the rest of this handbook describes.

5.2 Founding

An invitation-only founding cohort, entered with a valid founding code, which grants membership, study access and examination access together as a fee waiver layered over the standard flow. **The credential is still earned by passing the examination.** The founding route changes what you pay, not what you must demonstrate.

5.3 Honorary

Honorary Fellow (PCI) is a board-conferred recognition of distinguished contribution. Anyone may apply; the board reviews and decides. It carries its own award reference, is recorded separately from examined credentials, and **requires no examination**. It is not PCL-AI, PFL-AI or PML-AI, and no certification follows from it.

[CER-04](#) explains all three routes, what each one costs you in evidence rather than money, and the non-public administrative routes the platform also supports.

— 6. Applying

6.1 What the application consists of

Application is fully online. Before a booking will open, all of the following must be in place:

1. an account and a **complete profile**, including the country you will sit in;
 2. your **declared experience**, meeting §4.1;
 3. a valid **government-issued photo identification** document on file, whose name matches your booking **character for character**;
 4. acceptance of the **seven required policy consents** — the candidate handbook, the examination rules, the proctoring consent, the privacy notice, the refund policy, the misconduct policy and the credential terms — each at its current version;
 5. a **valid examination entitlement**: the fee paid, not refunded or reversed, and not past its scheduling deadline;
 6. an account in good standing, with no administrative hold.
-

If a booking will not open, it is because one of those six is outstanding, or because booking is closed platform-wide. [CER-03](#) §5.1 lists the conditions in the order the platform checks them, so you can self-diagnose in a minute rather than raising a ticket.

6.2 What payment buys

The examination fee buys **examination registration access**, and opens a **12-month window** in which to schedule and sit. It does not buy a credential. Certification is a decision taken after eligibility, assessment, verification and policy requirements are all met, and no purchase confers it.

6.3 Fees

The examination fee is [\[CONFIRM: exam fee — platform seeds USD 500, legacy pack states USD 350\]](#), in US dollars, as a single payment. Fees are **route-dependent and discountable**: what you pay depends on the route you enter by and on any discount in force, and the amount that binds you is the amount shown at checkout. [CER-05](#) owns fees, refunds and retakes.

— 7. Preparing

7.1 What you are assessed against

The Body of Knowledge — **13 domains and 61 knowledge areas**, in three groups weighted **40 / 40 / 20**: project accounting and finance (Domains 1–4) at 40 %, project management principles (Domains 5–12) at 40 %, and AI knowledge and practical approach (Domain 13) at 20 %. The framework you study is the framework you are assessed against.

7.2 Training is independent of assessment

PCI owns the standard and the examination. **Certuvo** is the separate official preparation and training partner. Preparation with any provider, or none, is your choice; the certification decision is independent of training, and no course guarantees a pass. That separation is part of what makes the credential worth holding.

7.3 Using AI while you prepare

In preparation, AI is welcome — explaining a concept, generating practice scenarios, testing your reasoning. You remain responsible for verifying anything an AI tool tells you against the Body of Knowledge. **In the examination itself, AI is prohibited**, on any device, for any purpose. The examination measures your judgement, including your judgement about AI. The governing principle of the whole framework is: AI proposes; the professional disposes.

— 8. The examination

8.1 Confirmed format

Fact	Value
Duration	90 minutes
Item format	Four-option multiple choice, single best answer
Cognitive levels	Recall, application and analysis — application-weighted
Scoring	Criterion-referenced, not graded on a curve
Formula sheet	None provided in the examination
Interface languages	English, Arabic, Spanish, French, Korean, Chinese, Russian
Result	Immediate, with a domain breakdown
Validity of a pass	3 years

8.2 What is deliberately not fixed

- **The number of items.** No item count exists. It **will be confirmed by a formal job-task analysis**. Any figure you see quoted elsewhere is not ours.
- **The definitive pass mark.** 65 % is the mark configured in the platform today. The definitive standard **will be set by a modified-Angoff standard-setting study**. Both statements are true at once, and the Institute publishes both rather than the more comfortable one.

EXB-05 – Standard setting: modified Angoff and the pass mark explains what a standard-setting study does and why a criterion-referenced examination cannot simply pick a number.

8.3 On the day

Launch opens **15 minutes before** your slot, with a **30-minute grace period**. You will complete a system readiness check and an identity check, then a room scan. The sitting is proctored: a second monitor is blocked, prohibited applications are detected, and integrity events are recorded. You cannot quit the examination — you submit when ready, or it submits automatically when time expires. Answers are saved continuously against a **server-owned clock**, so a disconnection or a restart does not lose your work or reset your time.

CER-06 sets out exactly what is monitored, what the secure client can and cannot do — including the things it honestly cannot block — and how long evidence is kept.

— 9. Results

9.1 Immediate, with a breakdown

On submission you receive your score, a pass or fail outcome against the configured standard, and a **domain-by-domain breakdown** showing where you performed above, at or below target. For an unsuccessful candidate that breakdown is the map for targeted preparation.

9.2 When a result is held

Immediate publication is the default. Proctoring and identity evidence is **audit-only** and does not by itself delay a valid result. A result is held only where there is a genuine question about the validity of the attempt. **While a result is held you see no score, no pass or fail, and no domain breakdown** — the Institute will not show you a number it may have to withdraw. You are told plainly that the result is pending and why.

9.3 The certification decision

Passing is the central requirement, not the whole of it. The credential is awarded after eligibility, assessment, verification and policy requirements are all met. On award you receive a verifiable digital credential with a unique credential identifier and a downloadable certificate, and the credential's status can be checked by anyone through PCI's public verification.

9.4 If you disagree

You may **appeal** a decision that affects you — eligibility, examination, misconduct or certification. An appeal is reviewed independently of the people who made the original decision, and raising one never prejudices your standing. A **complaint**, about PCI's conduct, service or process, is a separate route with separate people. [CER-07](#) explains both, and [ETH-06 – Raising concerns: complaints, investigations, sanctions](#) owns the investigation and outcome side.

— 10. Keeping the credential

A credential is valid for **three years** and is maintained on a three-year cycle of continuing professional development with a **mandatory AI-currency component** — the platform records it under a CPD category named exactly that. Only approved CPD entries dated within the current cycle count.

The binding hours requirement is [\[CONFIRM: binding CPD hours per three-year cycle — 30 hours is a student-portal target, not a published requirement\]](#) and **will be published with the recertification rules**. The 30-hour figure shown in the student portal is a target the portal displays, not a rule you can be held to. [CER-08](#) sets out the cycle, the four CPD categories, what evidence is expected and what happens if a cycle lapses.

— 11. Your obligations

Certification is a standing relationship, not a transaction. As a candidate and as a credential holder you are expected to:

1. present genuine identification and sit the examination yourself;
2. use no unauthorised materials, devices or assistance of any kind, including any AI tool;
3. follow the proctor's instructions throughout the session;
4. **not disclose examination content**, during or after the sitting — reconstructing, sharing or soliciting items is misconduct however informal the setting;

5. describe your credential accurately: it belongs to you, describes competence at the point of assessment and thereafter under maintenance, and may not be transferred, altered or used in a misleading way;
6. take full professional accountability for AI-assisted work, under the Code of Ethics and the professional conduct policy. "The model said so" is never a defence.

— 12. Where candidates come unstuck

The failures below are the ones that cost candidates a sitting, and every one of them is avoidable in the week before.

- **A name mismatch.** The name on the booking must match the identification exactly, character for character. Middle names, transliterations and married names are the usual culprits. Check it the week before, not the morning of.
- **Testing on the wrong machine.** Candidates run the readiness check on a personal laptop and then sit on a work machine with a managed security policy. Run the check on the actual machine, network and room you will use.
- **A second screen still plugged in.** A second monitor connected mid-examination is detected. Unplug it, do not merely switch it off.
- **Requesting an adjustment too late.** Approved arrangements are configured in advance. A request made on the day cannot be set up in time, and a legitimate rest break that was never recorded can be logged as an irregularity.
- **Letting the window lapse.** The scheduling window runs 12 months from payment. It is not extended because the twelfth month was busy.
- **Assuming a route changes the standard.** Founding and sponsored routes change what you pay. Nobody is certified without passing.
- **Reading a fee figure from an old document.** Fees are route-dependent and discountable, and this handbook flags an unresolved conflict between two published figures. The checkout amount governs.

— 13. The candidate's checklist

Take this into the four weeks before your sitting.

Eligibility and application

- [] Three years' full-time-equivalent experience, counted per [CER-03](#)
- [] Profile complete, including country
- [] Photo identification uploaded, name matching the booking character for character
- [] All seven policy consents accepted at their current version
- [] Examination fee paid, entitlement valid, scheduling deadline noted in your own calendar

Adjustments

- [] Any reasonable adjustment requested and approved **before** booking

Booking

- ☐ Slot booked inside the 12-month window
- ☐ Free-reschedule cut-off (72 hours) and lock (24 hours) understood
- ☐ Reschedules used: ____ of a maximum of 3

Readiness

- ☐ System readiness check completed on the actual machine, network and room
- ☐ Second monitor physically disconnected
- ☐ Room clear of notes, devices and other people; a door that can be closed
- ☐ Identification physically present for the identity check

On the day

- ☐ Launch within the 15-minute early window; grace period is 30 minutes, not a plan
- ☐ Any disruption reported to the proctor immediately, and to PCI the same day

After

- ☐ Domain breakdown saved and read against the 13 domains
- ☐ Credential identifier recorded; verification link tested
- ☐ Recertification cycle end date entered in your calendar on the day you are certified

— Related

- [CER-02 – The credential suite: PCL-AI, PFL-AI, PML-AI](#) — which of the three you should be applying for, and which one is examinable today
- [CER-03 – Eligibility, application and reasonable adjustments](#) — whether your three years count, and how to ask for an adjustment
- [CER-04 – Routes into PCI: standard, founding, honorary](#) — what each route grants and what it withholds
- [CER-05 – Booking, fees, rescheduling and cancellation](#) — every date and every amount, in one place
- [CER-06 – Online proctoring and the secure exam client](#) — what is watched, recorded and kept
- [CER-07 – Results, scoring, appeals and complaints](#) — how the result is decided and how to challenge it
- [CER-08 – Recertification, CPD and the AI-currency requirement](#) — keeping the credential alive
- [EXB-01 – Examination blueprint – PCL-AI](#) — the published syllabus behind the examination

— Sources and standards

- PCI platform examination and portal settings — the configured duration, pass mark, launch window, reschedule rules, scheduling window, proctoring switches and CPD settings, verified August 2026.

- PCI Candidate Handbook (<docs/downloads/candidate-handbook.md>), 2026 — the predecessor candidate-facing document, authored under a retired credential code that this handbook does not carry forward.
- PCI Publication Framework, <CANONICAL-FACTS.md> §§1–9, August 2026.
- **ISO/IEC 17024** — the international standard for bodies operating certification of persons. PCI's framework is developed with reference to its principles. PCI is **not accredited** against it, and this handbook cites it as a design reference only, not as a claim of conformity assessed by anyone.

— Status and version

Founding-stage document · Version 1.0 — effective date to be confirmed · draft · Reviewed under PCI governance. PCI makes no claims of accreditation or recognition beyond what is true today.